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RESEARCH ARTICLE

The law of concentrations of crime at place: the case of Tel Aviv-Jaffa

David Weisburd[a,b]* and Shai Amram[a,c]

[a]*Institute of Criminology, Faculty of Law, Hebrew University, Jerusalem, Israel;* [b]*Department of Criminology, Law and Society, George Mason University, Fairfax, VA, USA;* [c]*Research Department, Ministry of Public Security, Israel*

Weisburd, Groff, and Yang argue that there is a 'law of concentrations of crime at place' within cities. In this paper, we provide a test for this proposition in Tel Aviv-Jaffa. We found that crime concentrations at street segments in 2010 were remarkably similar to those observed in American cities. About 4.5% of the street segments produced approximately 50% of the crime, and about 1% of street segments produced 25% of crime. Our study provides important verification of the broad applicability of the law of crime concentrations at place.

Keywords: crime concentrations; hot spots of crime; crime and place; street segments; Tel Aviv-Jaffa

While the individual and 'macro' units of place such as the community have long been a focus of research and theory regarding social problems, only recently have scholars begun to explore crime and other anti-social behavior at very small 'micro' units of geography. The roots of such approaches can be found in the efforts of scholars to identify the relationship between specific aspects of urban design (Jeffery, 1971) or urban architecture (Newman, 1972) and anti-social behavior, but broadened to take into account a much larger set of characteristics of physical space and criminal opportunity (e.g. Brantingham & Brantingham, 1975). These studies drew important distinctions between the specific location of anti-social behavior and the larger geographical area (such as neighborhood, community, police beat, or city) that surrounds it.

The main theoretical impetus to the micro place approach to anti-social behavior is found in a group of theoretical perspectives that emerged in the late 1970s. In a seminal article on routine activities and crime, for example, Cohen and Felson (1979) suggested that a fuller understanding of crime must include a recognition that the availability of suitable crime targets and the presence or absence of capable guardians influence crime events. Routine activities focused attention on the specific ecological contexts in which suitable targets, motivated offenders, and the absence of capable guardians occurred. Researchers at the British Home Office in a series of studies examining the effects of 'situational crime prevention' also challenged the traditional focus on offenders and communities (e.g. see Clarke, 1983). In contrast to offender-based approaches to crime prevention, which usually focus on the dispositions of criminals, situational crime prevention begins with the opportunity structure (and immediate physical context) of the crime situation (Felson & Clarke, 1998). Paul and Patricia Brantingham also emphasized the role of place characteristics in shaping the type and frequency of human

*Corresponding author. Email: dweisbur@gmu.edu

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interaction in their work on environmental criminology (Brantingham & Brantingham, 1991).

One implication of these emerging perspectives was that places at a 'micro' geographic level should be an important focus of scholarly inquiry. While concern with the relationship between social problems and place is not new and indeed goes back to the founding generations of modern criminology, the 'micro' approach to places suggested by recent theories has just begun to be examined (Weisburd, Bernasco, & Bruinsma, 2009). Places in this 'micro' context are specific locations within the larger social environments of communities and neighborhoods (Eck & Weisburd, 1995). Recent studies point to the potential theoretical and practical benefits of focusing research on crime places. In particular, there has been a consistent finding that crime is tightly concentrated at just a small number of micro places in a city. For example, in one of the pioneering studies in this area, Sherman, Gartin, and Buerger (1989) found that only 3.5% of the addresses in Minneapolis produced 50% of all calls to the police. Fifteen years later in a retrospective longitudinal study in Seattle, Washington, Weisburd, Bushway, Lum, and Yang (2004) reported that between 4 and 5% of street segments in the city accounted for 50% of crime incidents for each year over 14 years.

The findings of remarkable concentrations of crime at place raise a more general question about the phenomenon of crime in cities. Is there some general law that applies across cities that dictates the general concentration of crime? This is the question raised in a recent book by Weisburd, Groff, and Yang (2012) titled *The Criminology of Place*. Studying crime at street segments in Seattle, they found a remarkable stability of crime concentrations each year over a 16-year period. They argue that these data, as well as prior studies showing similar concentrations of crime for specific years in other cities (e.g. see Pierce, Spaar, & Briggs, 1988; Sherman et al., 1989), suggest that crime concentrations at micro places are relatively constant with about 5% of places producing about 50% of crime in a city each year (see also Weisburd, Telep, & Lawton, in press).

The idea of a 'law' of crime rates is not a new one. Emile Durkheim raised this possibility more than a century ago. Durkheim suggested that crime was not indicative of pathology or illness in society, but at certain levels was simply evidence of the normal functioning of communities (Durkheim, 1895 [1964]). For Durkheim, the idea of a normal level of crime reinforced his theoretical position that crime helped to define and solidify norms in society. While Durkheim's proposition regarding a normal level of crime in society does not seem to fit recent experience and is seldom discussed by criminologists today, Weisburd et al. (2012) argue that there is indeed a 'normal level of crime' in cities, but one that relates to the concentration of crime at place and not to the overall rate of crime. While the absolute levels of crime in cities vary year to year, the extent of crime concentrations remains similar (Pierce et al., 1988; Sherman et al., 1989; Weisburd et al., 2004).

Weisburd et al.'s (2004) conclusions are based primarily on data on crime concentrations in Seattle and other American cities. In this paper, we examine such concentrations in Tel Aviv-Jaffa, Israel. If the 'law of crime concentrations' applies to Tel Aviv-Jaffa, then we have another important data point for advancing this proposition about crime concentrations in modern urban areas.

The concentration of crime at place

A number of studies beginning in the late 1980s suggest that significant clustering of crime at place exists, regardless of the specific unit of analysis defined (see Brantingham

& Brantingham, 1999; Crow & Bull, 1975; Pierce et al., 1988; Roncek, 2000; Sherman et al., 1989; Weisburd et al., 2004; Weisburd & Green, 1994; Weisburd, Maher, & Sherman, 1992; Weisburd, Morris, & Groff, 2009). Perhaps the most influential of these was Sherman et al.'s (1989) analysis of emergency calls to street addresses over a single year. Sherman et al. (1989) found that only 3.5% of the addresses in Minneapolis produced 50% of all calls to the police. They regarded these results as so startling that they called for a new area of study which they termed the 'criminology of place.'

Other studies produced similar evidence of the concentration of crime in crime hot spots. Weisburd and Mazerolle (2000), for example, found that approximately 20% of all disorder crimes and 14% of crimes against persons were concentrated in just 56 drug crime hot spots in Jersey City, New Jersey, an area that comprised only 4.4% of street segments and intersections in the city. Similarly, Eck, Gersh, and Taylor (2000) found that the most active 10% of places (in terms of crime) in the Bronx and Baltimore accounted for approximately 32% of a combination of robberies, assaults, burglaries, grand larcenies, and auto thefts. A study conducted by Weisburd et al. (2004) not only confirms the concentration of crime, but also the stability of such concentrations across a long time span. Weisburd et al. examined street segments in the city of Seattle from 1989 through 2002. They found that 50% of crime incidents over the 14-year period occurred at only 4.5% of the street segments. Crime concentrations appear to be greater in examining specific types of crime. In another study in Seattle, Weisburd, Morris et al. (2009) examined the concentration of crime incidents in which a juvenile was arrested. They found that only 86 street segments out of more than 25,000 accounted for one-third of all official juvenile arrest incidents over a 14-year period.

In a recent study, extending the research of Weisburd et al. (2004) in Seattle, Weisburd et al. (2012) found that crime concentrations continued at similar levels over the additional two-year period examined. Moreover, they found that the 1% of street segments in the city accounted for fully 23% of crime incidents. They also examined the extent to which such crime concentrations represented larger community area effects, or local processes generated at the street segment level. Their analyses suggest overall that there is tremendous street-by-street variability in developmental patterns of crime at street segments in Seattle (see also Groff, Weisburd, & Yang, 2010). For example, simple descriptive maps pointed to the spread of crime hot spots across Seattle. Though certain areas, like the downtown center of the city, evidenced larger numbers of chronic hot spots, hot spot street segments were generally dispersed throughout the city. They concluded that an approach that assumed that hot spots were clustered only in a few 'very bad' neighborhoods would misrepresent the spread of such problems in the city.

Similarly, drawing conclusions from spatial statistics, they found that trajectory patterns are interspersed, for example, with crime-free street segments often likely to be bounded by higher crime street segments, or chronic hot spots near to street segments evidencing less serious developmental patterns. Indeed, 85% of street segments within 800 feet (nearly 244 m) of chronic crime hot spots were places with little or no crime. While acknowledging that community and larger area processes are important for understanding crime, they conclude that the action of crime begins at a very micro level of geography, in their case the street segment.

While these studies suggest that there is indeed a law of concentrations of crime operating across cities, and that these crime concentrations at micro places are not simply a reflection of larger area trends, there is little known about the concentration of crime outside of the United States, and to some extent Australia, the UK, and Europe

where such studies are just beginning to emerge. Below we test the law of crime concentrations in the context of one such city, Tel Aviv-Jaffa, Israel.

The study

Our data are drawn from the city of Tel Aviv-Jaffa, which is the heart of Israel's largest metropolitan urban area. The city itself had a population of 404,400 for the year 2010, which makes it the second largest city in the country behind Jerusalem. But the metropolitan area of Tel Aviv-Jaffa includes a population of 3.3 million, nearly 43.4% of the total population of Israel. The city was established in 1909, and played a central role in the development of the Zionist movement in the country as the first new city in Palestine. It was the center of the political renaissance of Jewish institutions in Palestine, and of the new socialist labor movement of the twentieth century. It is today the economic and cultural capital of Israel. It is the home of the Israeli stock exchange and includes the corporate offices of many international companies based in Israel. It is also home to such key cultural institutions as the Israeli Opera, and Israel's most prestigious theater, 'HaBima.' And as a tourist attraction with entertainment available 24 hours a day, it is nicknamed in Israel 'the city that never sleeps.'

The city population is primarily of Jewish background (92%), though it includes a significant minority population composed of Arab Muslims and Christians and non-Arab Christians. The Arab population (3.9%) is concentrated in the old city of Jaffa, incorporated into Tel Aviv-Jaffa in 1948, and is primarily Muslim. Tel Aviv-Jaffa, like other major cities around the world, includes an overrepresentation of older citizens, younger professionals, and students. The rate of elderly persons (aged 65 or over) in Tel Aviv-Jaffa is 14.2% which is higher than the average number of elderly in the general population (9.7%). The rate of the younger population in the city aged 21–39 is 38.8%, while the national rate is 29.2%.

The city has emerged in recent years as a major urban center, which is reflected by the large growth of urban business towers and residences across the city. Tel Aviv-Jaffa's property crime rate was 54 incidents per 1000 persons, which placed it first among cities in Israel in 2010, the year of our study data. Tel Aviv-Jaffa's violent crime rate of 10.8 per 1000 persons is also one of the highest among Israeli cities.

Crime incidents at street segments

We used computerized records of written reports for the calendar year of 2010, often referred to as 'incident reports,' to examine crime trends. Tel Aviv-Jaffa experienced a total of 43,258 crime incidents during the research period. Incident reports are generated in Tel Aviv-Jaffa by police officers or detectives after an initial response to a request for police service or as a result of a crime identified by the police. In this sense, incident reports are more inclusive than arrest reports, but less inclusive than calls for service. Incident reports have been used in a series of other studies examining crime at place including those conducted by Weisburd and colleagues (see Weisburd et al., 2004, 2012; Weisburd & Green, 1995; Weisburd & Mazerolle, 2000; Weisburd et al., in press), thus allowing us to make direct comparisons to prior research.

The geographic unit of interest for this study is the street segment (sometimes referred to as a street block or face block) defined as the two block faces on both sides of a street between two intersections. We follow Weisburd et al. (2004, 2012) in choosing this unit of analysis and also follow their general logic for its utility. It is

important to note that the street segment approach fit easily to Tel Aviv-Jaffa in part because it is a new city which was created using the street grid model.

Scholars have long recognized the street segment's relevance in organizing life in the city (Appleyard, 1981; Brower, 1980; Jacobs, 1961; Taylor, Gottfredson, & Brower, 1984; Unger & Wandersman, 1983). Taylor (1997, 1998), for example, argues that the visual closeness of block residents, interrelated role obligations, acceptance of certain common norms and behavior, common regularly recurring rhythms of activity, the physical boundaries of the street, and the historical evolution of the street segment make the street block or street segment a particularly useful unit for analysis of place (see also Taylor et al., 1984).

Beyond the theoretical reasons for using street segments to understand crime at place, there are other advantages. Unlike neighborhood boundaries, street segments are easily recognized by residents and have well-defined boundaries (Taylor, 1988). Moreover, the small size of street segments minimizes spatial heterogeneity and makes for easier interpretation of significant effects (Rice & Csmith, 2002; Smith, Frazee, & Davison, 2000), and processes of informal social control and territoriality (Taylor et al., 1984) are more effective in smaller settings such as street segments.

Operationally, the choice of street segments over even smaller units such as addresses (see Sherman et al., 1989) also minimizes the error likely to develop from miscoding of addresses in official data (see Klinger & Bridges, 1997; Weisburd & Green, 1994). We recognize, however, that crime events may be linked across street segments. For example, a drug market may operate across a series of blocks (Weisburd & Green, 1995; Worden, Bynum, & Frank, 1994), and a large housing project and problems associated with it may transverse street segments in multiple directions (see Skogan & Annan, 1994). Nonetheless, the street segment offers a useful compromise because it allows a unit of analysis large enough to avoid unnecessary crime coding errors, but small enough to avoid aggregation that might hide specific trends. Importantly, as well, a number of prior studies have utilized the street segment when examining crime concentrations at places.

Following Weisburd et al. (2012; see also Groff et al., 2010), we operationalized the definition of street segments by referring directly to the geography of streets in Tel Aviv-Jaffa. Prior studies have generally relied upon what are often defined as hundred blocks to approximate the geography of street segments (e.g. Groff, Weisburd, & Morris, 2009; Weisburd et al., 2004, Weisburd, Morris et al., 2009). In this approach, researchers assume that the actual streets in a city follow the overall rule that a street segment includes addresses ranging a hundred numbers, for example from 1–100, or 101–200. While this approach is common and identifies broadly the geography of street segments in the city, we wanted our study to match as much as possible the reality of the behavioral settings of streets between intersections. We defined 17,160 valid street segments in Tel Aviv-Jaffa. The average length of a street segment was 205 feet, or 62 m. The majority of the streets (roughly 75%) are between 163 and 220 feet (50–67 m). Using our definition, very few streets (less than 3%) ended up longer than 330 feet (101 m).

In linking crime incidents to street segments, we exclude records of crimes that occur on the Tel Aviv-Jaffa beach, the central station area, and for non-residential or business road types such as highways and regional roads. We geocoded the remaining incident reports (excluding those without address identifiers) and were left with 39,392 incidents, nearly 91% of the total recorded crime incidents during that period. The geocoding process was carried out using ArcGIS 10 with a geocoding locator utilized

by the police information technology unit. To convert a crime point's location into a street segment ($N = 17{,}160$), we used the Spatial Join tool to join attributes from one feature, the point location, to another attribute, the street segment, based on a spatial relationship.

Results

The concentration of crime at place

Figure 1 presents the overall concentration of crime incidents at street segments in Tel Aviv-Jaffa. The results are startling in their similarity to the findings of studies in US cities. As we noted earlier, studies of crime concentrations have generally found between 3 and 6% of places produce about 50% of crimes or crime calls to the police. In the most comparable study conducted to date in Seattle, Washington (Weisburd et al., 2012), between 4.7 and 6% of street segments over a 16-year period produced 50% of crime incidents. In Tel Aviv-Jaffa in 2010, 4.5% of the street segments produced approximately 50% of the crime. This consistency is striking and reinforces the proposition that we posed earlier of a law of concentrations of crime at place.

When we examine where 25% of crime is located in the city, our findings are reinforced. Just 0.9% of street segments in Tel Aviv-Jaffa include one quarter of all crime. This means that just 159 street segments in the city are responsible for a quarter of the crime at street segments. Again, this is very similar to the results of the study in Seattle, conducted by Weisburd et al. (2012). As we noted earlier, they found that the 1% of street segments that were the most chronic hot spots of crime in the city included about 23% of all crime incidents over a 16-year period.

It is also the case that in Tel Aviv-Jaffa, as well as in American cities that have been studied, most street segments have little or no crime. Comparing Tel Aviv-Jaffa to Seattle in this case, Tel Aviv-Jaffa seems to have even a larger proportion of crime-free streets segments. In Tel Aviv-Jaffa, about two-thirds of the street segments did not have a reported crime in all of 2010, while in Seattle the number across the study period averaged around 40% (see Weisburd et al., 2012).

A key question in prior studies has been whether crime at place varies significantly within larger areas. If, for example, crime was concentrated at a small

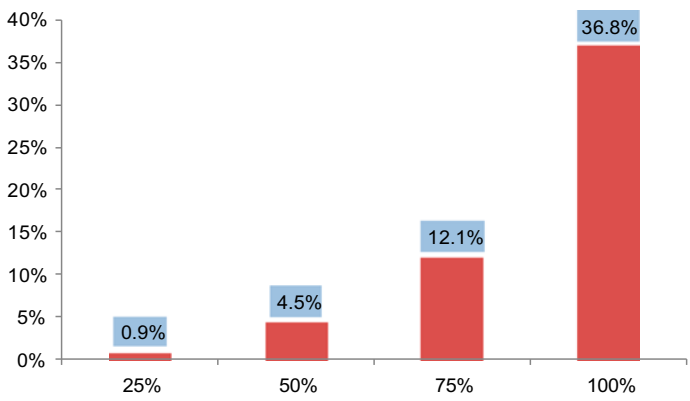

Figure 1. The proportion of street segments that account for 25%, 50%, 75% and 100% of crime.

number of streets, but all of those streets were clustered together in a single community, than the concept of hot spots of micro crime places would be challenged. Rather it would be relevant to speak of hot neighborhoods, as has long been a tradition in criminology (e.g. Bursik & Grasmick, 1993; Greenberg, Rohed, & Williams, 1982; Sampson, Raudenbush, & Earls, 1997). We noted earlier that prior studies in the US have found that there is important street-by-street variability in crime. Is the concentration of crime at micro places in Tel Aviv-Jaffa a reflection of micro areas processes?

Looking at Tel Aviv-Jaffa tells a very similar story in this regard to US studies. Figures 2(a)–(c) show street-by-street crime counts for Tel Aviv-Jaffa. The darker the shading, the higher the number of crime incidents at that street. For purposes of simplification, we divide counts into five groups. The most serious crime hot spots are represented in black (51 + crime incidents). They include just 0.3% of the street segments of Tel Aviv-Jaffa but some 15% of the crime. The next group, coded dark gray, also includes crime hot spots in the city but with lower intensity (16–50 crime incidents). At the other end of the scale are the two-thirds of street segments with no crimes in the study period colored white.

There are clearly area influences. For example, Figure 2(a) which shows the wealthier more residential Northern part of Tel Aviv-Jaffa, including Tel Aviv University, is dominated by streets with no or little crime. At the same time, even in the northernmost part of the city, which is affluent and highly residential, there are pockets of gray-colored streets which had between 5 and 15 crime incidents in one year. And

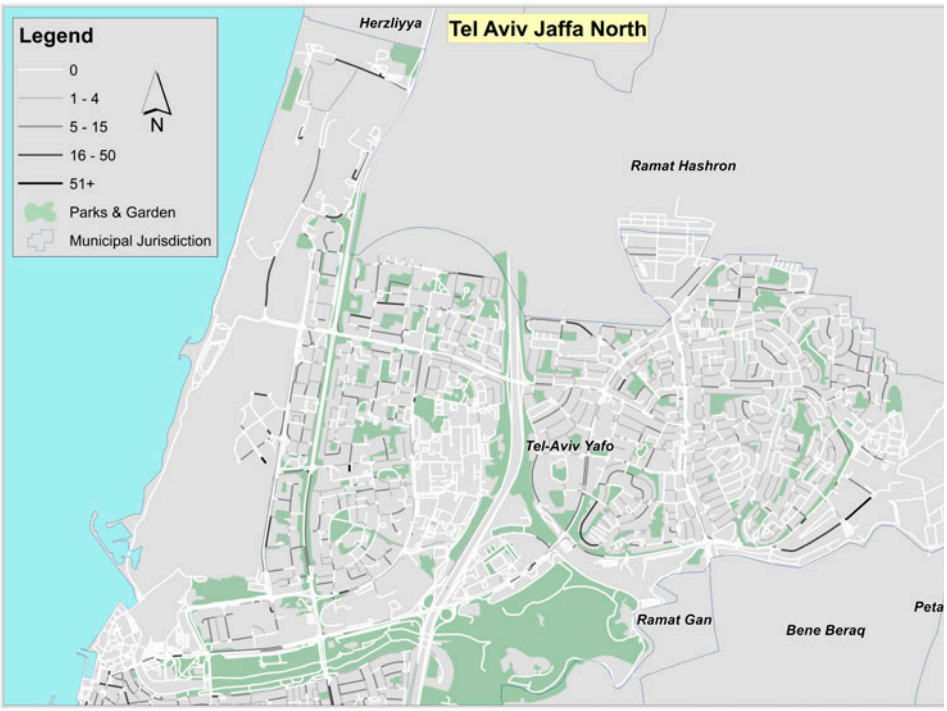

Figure 2(a). Crime patterns at street segments: North Tel Aviv-Jaffa.

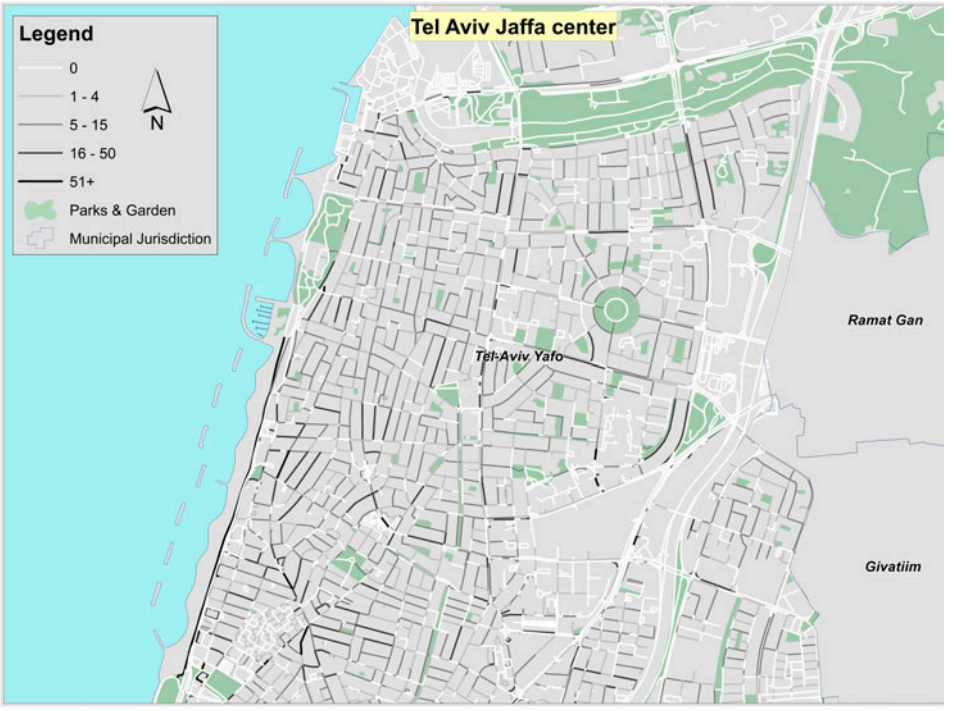

Figure 2(b). Crime patterns at street segments: Center Tel Aviv-Jaffa.

there are scattered dark gray and black lines, representing more chronic hot spot street segments as you move toward Central Tel Aviv-Jaffa.

The central area of Tel Aviv-Jaffa (see Figure 2(b)), including the main business district, has many more streets with serious crime problems. But even here, the vast majority of streets have little or no crime as represented by the white and light gray lines. Note the tremendous street-to-street variability of crime levels in this map, with white, light gray, and gray street segments interspersed. And in this case, there are a number of chronic hot spots street segments as represented by the black and dark gray lines. Importantly, while there is some clustering of such high crime streets in specific areas, there is still a good deal of street-by-street variability, for example, with gray, light gray, and white lines often adjacent or close by.

The southern neighborhoods of Tel Aviv-Jaffa (Figure 2(c)), which include an area around the Central Bus Station which is known for high numbers of illegal immigrants and homeless, do indeed have higher crime concentrations on average. And the area around the Central Bus Station has the highest concentration of chronic crime hot spots (black and dark gray lines) in the city. But such hot spots can also be found in other areas here, and there is a great deal of street-by-street variability in the colors observed across the areas, as was true of the earlier maps. Importantly, most streets even in what is generally described as a high crime area of Tel Aviv-Jaffa have little or no crime as evidenced by the light gray- and white-colored streets.

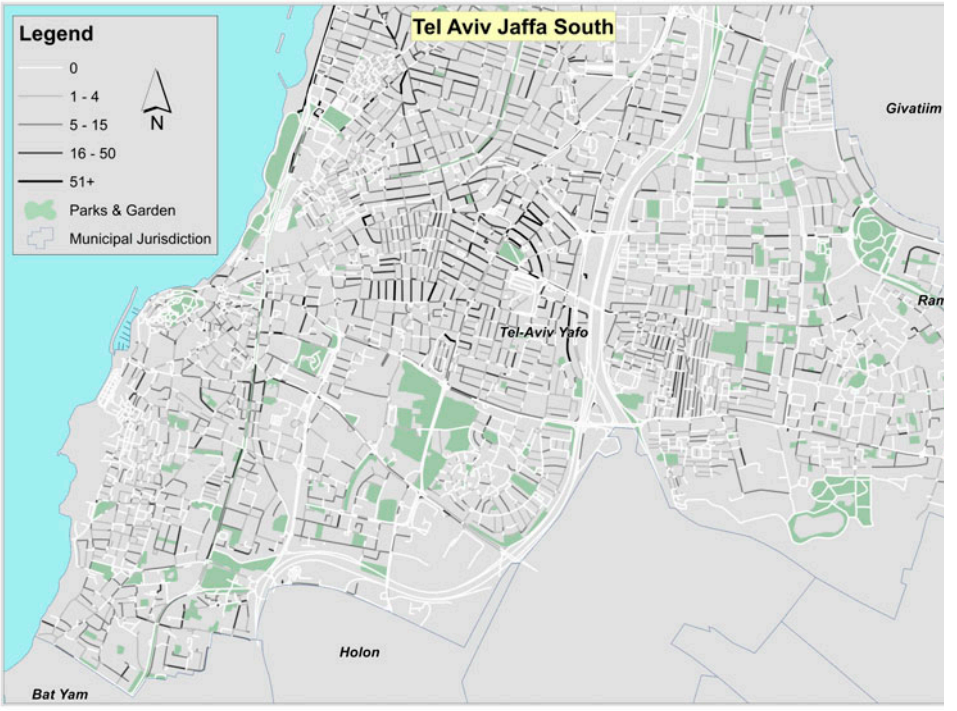

Figure 2(c). Crime patterns at street segments: South Tel Aviv-Jaffa.

Discussion

We find looking at crime incidents in Tel Aviv-Jaffa that crime is tightly concentrated at place. Just 4.5% of the street segments in the city have 50% of crime, and just 0.9% of the street segments include 25% of crime incidents over a year. These crime concentrations at street segments moreover are not simply reflective of neighborhood trends. While there are clearly larger area influences on crime in Tel Aviv-Jaffa, there is also tremendous street-to-street variability within neighborhoods. Even in the 'best neighborhoods' in Tel Aviv-Jaffa, there are crime hot spots. And in the neighborhoods that are often seen as problematic, most streets have little or no crime, and there is often variability in crime street to street.

Our findings, as we noted above, are particularly interesting in light of Emile Durkheim's classic proposition that the level of crime is stable in society, or rather that there was a 'normal level' of crime in society. For Durkheim, this meant that crime was not necessarily an indication of an illness or pathology in society, but rather that healthy societies would inevitably have some normal level of crime. Crime waves and crime drops in this context can be seen as the result of some 'abnormality' in society that results from crisis or dramatic social change.

Underlying Durkheim's proposition is his understanding of crime as a product of social definition. Kai Erickson (1966) was to build upon this idea in his classic study *Wayward Puritans*, where he sought to show that the definition of crime had a social function. By defining others as deviant, society can help draw the boundaries between acceptable and unacceptable conduct (see also Adler & Adler, 2009; Becker, 1963).

Defining people as criminal in this sense serves a function in defining the moral boundaries of society. We can know the boundaries of acceptable behavior by observing 'deviants' who are sanctioned for violating societal norms.

Crime rates over the last few decades would seem to strongly contradict Durkheim's conception of normal levels of crime in society. Between 1973 and 1990, violent crime doubled (Reiss & Roth, 1993), and in the 1990s the US experienced a well-documented 'crime drop' (Blumstein & Wallman, 2000). In the 1970s, Alfred Blumstein and colleagues (Blumstein & Cohen, 1973; Blumstein, Cohen, & Nagin, 1976; Blumstein & Moitra, 1979) hypothesized that Durkheim's proposition could be applied to punishment in America, where imprisonment rates had remained static for a long period of time (see also Tremblay, 1986). But recent dramatic increases in US incarcerations in the 1980s and 1990s would seem inconsistent with the normal crime, or 'normal punishment' (Blumstein & Cohen, 1973) hypothesis. Unless of course, we were to postulate that these are periods of dramatic social change.

Weisburd et al. (2012) argue that there is indeed a 'normal level of crime' in cities, but one that relates to the concentration of crime at place and not to the overall rate of crime. They claim that a different proposition from Durkheim's can be raised at this juncture, and should be examined in future studies. There appears to be a 'law of concentrations' of crime at place. Our study provides important support for this proposition since it is one of the first studies of crime concentrations at micro places outside of the US. The consistency of crime concentrations at micro places in Tel Aviv-Jaffa and American cities suggests that there is some underlying social process pushing crime to certain levels of concentration in modern cities.

Can we use Durkheim's initial insights to consider possible reasons for this law of concentrations of crime at place? If we follow Durkheim and other theorists that built on his work, we would look to the role of crime at place in defining normative boundaries in society. In this case, we might argue that a certain number of places in the city with severe crime problems serve as lessons for the city more generally. This would fit well with our finding that crime hot spots are found throughout the city. Accordingly, we all have direct visceral experiences with the 'bad places' in the city, and perhaps that serves to define for the rest of us the 'moral boundaries' of place. The normal level of crime concentrations in this context would relate to the proportion of problem places that are needed to bring the lessons of moral boundaries to the city's residents.

Another possible explanation for a law of concentrations comes from the concentration of other characteristics of places in the city. For example, Weisburd et al. (2012) note that the concentrations of bus stops or number of public facilities like crime stay relatively stable over long periods. Perhaps the law of concentrations of crime is related to the overall distribution of social and environmental characteristics of places in cities. Does the stability of patterns of business and employment in a city, for example, reflect more general patterns of concentration that are related to the growth and development of urban areas? Certainly cities regulate such concentrations, by defining commercial, business, and industrial use of property. Perhaps the normal concentrations of crime are simply a reflection of the normal concentrations of other social activities in the city. The law of concentrations of crime at place may simply be a reflection of a more general law of the stability of concentrations of specific aspects of social and economic life in the city. This is suggested by Juran (1951) who first noted a general rule for the concentration of social and economic activities. He called this rule the Pareto Principle, coining the phrase 'the vital few and the trivial many.'

But this brings us back to Durkheim, because crime is a social phenomenon and its tolerance is a social construct. Is society willing to tolerate crime at only a certain proportion of the landscape of a city? Is the law of concentrations a result of the boundaries of crime at place that citizens are willing to tolerate? Will people become worried and call for action when crime hot spots increase beyond a specific proportion of places in the city, and will they become more lax when the concentrations are below that level?

Conclusion

We think that our data in Tel Aviv-Jaffa add strong reason to continue to explore explanations for a law of concentrations of crime at place. The fact that cities thousands of miles apart from each other, with very different populations and social norms, have virtually identical crime concentrations at micro places is an intriguing and important finding. Certainly, this law of concentrations needs to be studied across other metropolitan centers around the world to see how widely it applies. More generally, it is time for scholars to explore more directly the explanation for the law of concentrations of crime trends at micro places. In the spatial context, scholars should explore street segments characteristics, social and environmental, that are important to understanding the concentration of crime at place.

Finally, we want to emphasize the crime prevention policy implications of our study for Israel. Given that crime in Tel Aviv-Jaffa is concentrated at micro places so too should police activity be concentrated at this geographic level. The Israeli National Police has generally considered crime problems at macro geographic levels like neighborhoods or cities. It is time to recognize that the action of crime is often at a much more local geographic level, like the street segment. Evidence from hot spots policing programs suggests that the police can be effective in preventing crime when they focus on micro geographic hot spots (e.g. see Braga & Bond, 2008; Sherman & Weisburd, 1995; Weisburd & Green, 1995). Our data show that such an approach is relevant to the Israeli case.

Notes on contributors

David Weisburd is Walter E. Meyer Professor of Law and Criminal Justice at the Hebrew University Faculty of Law in Jerusalem and Distinguished Professor of Criminology, Law and Society at George Mason University in Fairfax. His latest book, The Criminology of Place: Street Segments and Our Understanding of the Crime Problem, was published by Oxford University Press in 2012. He is the 2010 recipient of the Stockholm Prize in Criminology and the 2011 recipient of the Klachky Prize for the Advancement of the Frontiers of Science.

Shai Amram is a doctoral student in the Institute of Criminology, Hebrew University, Jerusalem. He currently serves as a research assistant in Research Department in the Ministry of Public Security, Israel. His major research interests are the areas of geographic criminology, spatial modeling, program and policy evaluation, crime displacement, and urban planning. He received his BA (1996) and MA (2000) from the Hebrew university in Geography and Urban Planning. He previously served as a research assistant at the Research and Statistical unit in Israel Police.

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